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THE BUSH TELEGRAPH
WILDLY GOOD NEWS

A FRESH START FOR THE BUSH

The role of block burns in managing DGR

After the first rains, the bushveld begins its seasonal transformation. But while rain brings new life, it also signals an important time for one of DGR's annual management activities: the block-burning programme.

This year, the programme aims to burn 4,000 hectares of veld in the South of the reserve. The team will work to complete the planned burns as quickly as possible, while remaining dependent on suitable temperatures, wind, humidity and other conditions to ensure each burn can be carried out safely.

Block burns are about much more than setting fire to dry grass. It is a practical tool for managing vegetation, maintaining a healthy bushveld and helping keep fuel loads under control.

Managing the bush, one block at a time

Over time, grass and other vegetation accumulate, and the balance between grassland and thicker bush can change. Carefully planned burns help manage this vegetation and maintain a more varied landscape.

DGR uses a mosaic approach, with selected blocks burnt while other areas remain untouched. Rather than burning large areas indiscriminately, this creates a patchwork of veld at different stages of recovery.

This variety matters. It provides different habitats and grazing opportunities for wildlife, while leaving unburnt areas that animals can use for shelter and refuge.

Block burns also reduce the amount of dry vegetation available to feed an uncontrolled fire. Although they cannot eliminate wildfire risk, strategically reducing fuel loads can help limit the intensity and spread of future fires.

A favourite with the wildlife

There is another benefit to the mosaic approach, one that wildlife quickly takes advantage of.

Many grazing animals are attracted to freshly burnt veld once new grass starts emerging. The young growth is often more nutritious and appealing than older, mature grass, making burnt blocks popular feeding areas.

As new shoots appear, animals move into these areas to graze. This natural response to changing food availability is one of the reasons why a mosaic of recently burnt and unburnt areas is valuable. For visitors, it can also create wonderful wildlife-viewing opportunities as animals gather to take advantage of the fresh growth.

Why the first 25 mm of rain matters

In DGR, the first rainfall of at least 25 mm within a 24-hour period is the established trigger in the reserve's fire management plan for starting the annual block-burning programme. It reflects a generally accepted vegetation-management practice and results in much colder fires.

Reaching the 25 mm trigger allows the programme to begin, but it does not mean every block is burnt immediately. Temperature, wind, humidity and veld conditions must still be assessed on a daily basis. The team will work towards completing the planned 4,000 hectares as quickly as possible this year and as conditions safely allow.



The people behind the programme

A key part of this work is the 25-member Working on Fire (WOF) team that operates in DGR each year.

Working on Fire, a programme funded by the Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment, plays an important role in fire management across South Africa. In DGR, the team's contribution extends beyond responding to fires during the fire season. Its members also assist with planned burning and the ongoing work needed to manage vegetation and reduce fuel loads.

The work requires training, teamwork, discipline and a good understanding of fire behaviour. It is a demanding responsibility, and the team's contribution helps protect the reserve while supporting the long-term management of its natural environment.

As another season of block burns is in full swing, we recognise the WOF team and DGR Rangers involved in this important programme. Every carefully managed block helps shape the bushveld, creates fresh grazing opportunities and contributes to a healthier, more resilient reserve.

Sometimes, giving the bush a fresh start means knowing exactly where, when and how to burn.

The Bush Telegraph, Connecting Our Community, One Story at a Time.

An independent newsletter celebrating conservation, community and the people of DGR.

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